



STATEMENT

BY

**HIS EXCELLENCY MR. MOHAMMED B. S.
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**VICE PRESIDENT OF THE REPUBLIC OF
THE GAMBIA**

**AT THE
GENERAL DEBATE OF THE 80TH SESSION
OF THE
UNITED NATIONS GENERAL ASSEMBLY**

**NEW YORK
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**Your Excellency Annalena Baerbock,
President of the 80th Session of the UN General
Assembly,
H.E Antonio Guterres, Secretary General of the
United Nations,
Your Majesties, Excellencies, Heads of State and
Government,
Heads of Delegation,
Distinguished Delegates,
Ladies and Gentlemen,**

As we commemorate the 80th Anniversary of the United Nations, it is with great honour that I deliver this statement on behalf of His Excellency Mr. Adama Barrow, President of the Republic of The Gambia and the Government and People of The Gambia.

Madam President,

Let me use this opportunity to congratulate you on behalf of the Government of The Gambia on your election as President of the 80th Session of the United Nations General Assembly. The Gambia assures you of its unwavering support and continued cooperation in the discharge of your duties.

Permit me also to seize this moment to thank Mr. Philemon Yang, President of the 79th Session of the General Assembly for his wise leadership and for competently guiding the work of the Assembly during his tenure.

Madam President,

This Session is being held at a very pivotal moment for the international community. The enormity of the challenges of managing and resolving the ongoing and sporadic wars, conflicts, and threats to international peace and security require all Member

States to reaffirm their faith and collective commitment to the noble principles of the UN Charter.

The Charter was crafted with great optimism to herald a new age and a new world that would reverse the horrors of the past and define a common destiny premised on our shared humanity. To keep these hopes alive, we must rekindle the ethos of solidarity through more multilateral engagement.

Madam President,

The Session holds a profound symbolism of progress for The Gambia. Against our long-standing commitment to the United Nations, our election as Chair of the 2nd Committee this year is historic, and it speaks to the great strides made towards shaping a stable and prosperous multilateral global order.

We remain committed to the search for innovative and timely solutions to our global challenges and will collaborate with all Member States to resolve them.

Madam President,

The United Nations (UN) serves as a driving force for multilateralism and the reaffirmation of the world's collective faith in the sanctity of human rights, international peace, and security the world over. Importantly, however, the commemoration of the founding of the Organisation this year calls for a keener probe into the future and a reassertion of the UN as the premier global institution entrusted with the destiny of humanity.

We must now do more to fulfil the commitments we assumed under the Pact for the Future. The protracted challenges of conflict and geopolitical fragmentation, including the threat to the spirit of multilateralism under the United Nations, doggedly linger on.

As the world grapples with complex and unprecedented challenges on various fronts, the peace and security landscape is becoming increasingly fragile.

Amid the changing nature of conflict, we are continually witnessing consequential disregard for the principles of International Humanitarian Law in conflict zones. It is even more threatening that the rules-based international order is under enormous stress, thus losing its momentum, relevance, and moral underpinnings.

The consequence of these developments reflects a desperate international community in search of answers to multiple predicaments simultaneously. Intricate as this may seem, The Gambia acknowledges that the UN's enduring relevance and structural institutions contributed to momentous achievements of the past, particularly for countries in the global South.

In the case of The Gambia, the UN used its convening power and preventive diplomacy via the Peacebuilding Commission to support the democratically elected government that assumed office in 2017.

That support was key to upholding the will of the Gambian people, ushering in the current government, and initiating a transitional justice system to promote democracy, the rule of law, and respect for human rights.

Madam President,

As we reflect on the timely adopted theme for this Session, “**Better Together: 80 years and more for peace, development and human rights,**” we must admit that the daunting challenges we face today require deliberate investment in sustainable development, climate action, peace, and security.

Since the change of government in 2017, the administration of His Excellency, Mr. Adama Barrow, has been pursuing the path of inclusive development, peace, and respect for fundamental rights and freedoms. It strictly commits to according the needs of people topmost priority on our national development agenda.

With the current national reform agenda for inclusive governance, Gambians set their eyes on building a future of immense potential and opportunities, partly through the implementation of the recommendations of our Truth, Reconciliation and Reparations Commission.

Over the past eight (8) years, the government successfully organised credible, transparent, and both nationally and internationally endorsed rounds of national elections.

Preparations are progressing smoothly for the 2026 Presidential Election, and we remain resolved to maintaining international standards and consolidating participatory democracy, sustainable development, and good governance.

Madam President,

In our drive for broader reforms, we are building stronger state institutions, initiating legislative reforms and expanding the scope of our criminal jurisdiction to prosecute international atrocity crimes.

Such reforms include the enactment of the Special Prosecutor's Office Act 2024 to handle international crimes and serious rights violations. For the first time, we now have an Anti-Corruption Act to institute an Anti-Corruption Commission.

These examples typify efforts to deliver restorative and transformative justice, prevent impunity, construct a just and durable path towards nation-building, and lay an unshakeable foundation for social justice.

To support our development ambitions, as enshrined in our National Development Plan (YIRIWA) 2023-2027, we have operationalised a national budgeting mechanism grounded in human development to promote investment and national development.

Our goal is to rise above our socio-economic challenges through inclusive engagement in democratic governance. This has propelled us to ensure that democracy, respect for fundamental rights, and the building of institutional mechanisms sustainably thrive.

In building a peaceful society, we recognise the integral role of young people and women and, therefore, support their representation and participation in the democratic functioning of the state.

Madam President,

In parallel, we value the consolidation of democracy and good governance in our neighbourhood. In this spirit, The Gambia recently hosted the Sahel Governance Forum to galvanise a multi-stakeholder convergence to address and find definitive solutions to governance challenges that hamper peace, stability, and development in the Sahel.

Spurred on by a strong commitment to international peace, security, and human rights, The Gambia remains a staunch member of the African Union Peace and Security Council, the UN Human Rights Council, and participates in peacekeeping operations.

The Gambia continues to promote international peace and security as well as the consolidation of democratic governance and partnerships for African security.

It is significant that the AU and the UN collaborate closely to address regional peace and security matters, and this includes recalibration of preventive diplomacy tools for maximum impact. Likewise, the need to strengthen early warning mechanisms and prioritise the protection of children affected by armed conflict is strongly evident.

Madam President,

By re-echoing the mantra of “The Africa we want” and “An Africa at peace with itself,” The Gambia believes that more needs to be invested in conflict prevention. Consequently, we call on the UN Security Council to fulfil its responsibility towards resolving the unrest in Africa and elsewhere.

The rising levels of inequality are indicative of the unequal global economic system, creating huge imbalances for countries in the Global South, particularly in Africa, to address poverty, debt, and unemployment.

It is indeed disheartening that five years towards the end of the targeted Agenda 2030 deadline, much remains to be accomplished. Worse still, the realisation of its goals and milestones appear to be profoundly remote.

Madam President,

The high death rates, displacements, and untold suffering of civilians in the Middle East, Asia, Africa, Europe, and other corners of the world are truly unacceptable. All the raging conflicts around the world need to stop immediately.

Fortunately, the 2025 peacebuilding architecture review presents a golden opportunity to agree on stronger preventive arrangements and measures for conflict prevention.

As members of the United Nations and conscientious global citizens, we must continue to collectively pursue responsive and purposive actions by exhorting all hostile factions to dialogue for peace.

We must also contribute to effective security arrangements and frameworks not only to prevent conflicts but also protect civilians, particularly women, children, and the elderly.

Contending parties in each conflict zone must allow immediate and uninterrupted humanitarian aid to reach the suffering populations and commit to ending all hostilities. The bleeding must stop soonest.

Madam President,

The plight of the Palestinians remains unresolved, with innocent civilians continuing to face shocking difficulties under dire humanitarian conditions. Yet, the Palestinian predicament predominantly rests on the core principles of justice, respect for international humanitarian law, and self-determination.

As such, we cannot remain unperturbed by the worsening state of affairs in that region. It is imperative that we act urgently and collectively to revitalise the prospects for an inclusive peace process for Israel, Palestine, and the region.

In this context, The Gambia re-echoes its call for a two-state solution to urgently enable the Palestinian people to regain their legitimate national rights, as conceived by the International Community through its recognition of a State of Palestine within the 1967 borders, with Al-Quds Al Shareef as its capital.

We support the membership of Palestine into the United Nations. In this spirit, we commend the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia and France for the recently concluded High-level Conference on the Question of Palestine.

Madam President,

The Gambia applauds and supports the efforts of the UN Secretary-General in relaunching the Moroccan Sahara round table process to achieve a realistic and sustainable political solution in that regional dispute. We also welcome Morocco's commitment to the ceasefire, full cooperation with MINURSO, and relaunching of the political process, based on the parameters of Resolution 2756 (2024).

In this regard, we call on Polisario to abandon its unilateral withdrawal from the ceasefire and lift restrictions imposed on the freedom of movement and provision of supplies to MINURSO. By the same token, we urge all parties, Morocco, Algeria,

Mauritania and Polisario, to work towards a pragmatic and sustainable political solution based on compromise.

The positive impact of the Moroccan Autonomy Initiative, which we accept as realistic and credible, is already well received, and the people of the region continue to enjoy peace, development, and the protection of their human rights; thanks to the Government of the Kingdom of Morocco's New Development Model for the Moroccan Sahara Region.

Furthermore, The Gambia lauds the launch by His Majesty Mohammed VI, King of Morocco, of the Morocco-Nigeria Gas Pipeline, the Atlantic African Initiative, and the Sahel Countries Access to the Atlantic. These three Royal Initiatives will give a new impetus to the Moroccan Sahara Region by establishing it as a new platform of security, stability, and development.

Madam President,

The Gambia continues to stand with the People's Republic of China on their One China Policy. China's commitment to international cooperation and broad development support instructively exposes the elasticity of sustainable development and expansion of South-South and Triangular Cooperation prospects.

Similarly, The Gambia reiterates the call for lifting the economic embargo imposed on the brotherly people of Cuba. The embargo continues to inflict undue hardship and economic devastation, hence occasioning substantial challenges for the Government and People of Cuba. We believe it should give way to friendly cooperation. That is the way forward.

Madam President,

As we mark twenty-five (25) years since the adoption of Security Council Resolution 1325 on Women, Peace, and Security, we should firmly renew the conviction that the attainment of sustainable development and the consolidation of peace and security are anchored in the principle of inclusive representation for women in all spheres of political and decision-making processes.

While considerable progress has been made towards women's inclusion in public life, their participation in the consolidation of peace and security continues to be constrained by significant impediments that we must dislodge. Because they usually bear the brunt of unrests, women must always participate in discussions on conflict and peace.

As nations sharing the same destiny, and in preparation for the fourth (4th) World Conference on Women, we have the moral obligation and collective responsibility to act swiftly to address all issues hampering the empowerment of women. These include institutional advancement and increasing women's contribution to peace and security consolidation.

Madam President,

In view of the outcome of FfD4, it is our hope that the international financial architecture and mechanisms will change for the better. Meanwhile, the current international financing architecture, especially on debt restructuring, continues to hinder the development aspirations of developing countries.

Due to limited fiscal space exerted by distressing debt burdens, developing countries find it hard to make significant investments in the social sectors.

The challenge is even more profound with regard to investments in the productive base of their economies to engender growth, employment, and development.

The situation has contributed remarkably to the dismal attainment of only seventeen percent (17%) of the SDGs. To accelerate the full and effective implementation of the SDGs within the targeted timeframe, we must enhance international finance cooperation and review the international financial architecture.

We must create arrangements, facilities, and mechanisms that would cater for targeted investments, industrialisation, and mechanisation initiatives for development strides in all sectors.

Madam President,

The Pact for the Future, adopted at the 79th Session of the General Assembly, presents a huge opportunity to review our realities, invigorate the implementation of SDG Agenda 2030, and intensify efforts to confront the pressing challenges of the time.

The Gambia supports convening the preparatory process to review the Pact in 2028 and align it effectively with all relevant inter-governmental processes, such as the 2025 Peacebuilding Architecture Review, the High-level Plenary meeting to commemorate the 30th Anniversary of the World Programme of Action on Youth, and the World Social Summit.

The success of these reviews depends primarily on our commitment and concerted push to build a more equitable and resilient global governance framework that supports the attainment of our global goals.

Madam President,

The UN reform agenda will remain incomplete without reform of the UN Security Council. The Gambia supports the Common African position on reforming the Council, as set out in the Sirte Declaration and the Ezulwini Consensus.

We strongly believe that Africa's under-representation in the permanent and non-permanent categories of the Security Council is a historical injustice that needs urgent correction.

Africa has always contributed to global peace, and Africans paid a high price for participating in the two World Wars.

The Gambia believes that the time has come for the international community to support Africa's call for meaningful representation in the Security Council. Doing so will guarantee the Council's legitimacy and credibility as the body responsible for maintaining international peace and security.

We commend the AU Committee of Ten Heads of State and Government on the United Nations Security Council Reforms (C-10), chaired by His Excellency the President of the Republic of Sierra Leone, for ably spearheading this legitimate quest.

Madam President,

As we witness heightened levels of insecurity worldwide, the threat of climate change continues to aggravate security challenges, especially in the Sahel. We thus have to address the impact of the climate crisis as part of vital resilience measures to mitigate climate-related risks that intersect with political, social, and economic factors.

The Gambia acknowledges the progress made at COP29 in Baku, Azerbaijan, for moving from one billion dollars (US\$100 billion) to the NEW COLLECTIVE QUANTIFIED GOAL (NQCG), which is still inadequate to finance all the mitigation and adaptation actions, especially for countries in special circumstances.

It is essential to take concrete decisions at COP30 in Belem, Brazil, to galvanise support for more climate financing. The Gambia calls for more ambitious Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) by all states, due for submission this year, to achieve net-zero emissions by 2050.

Madam President,

Before concluding, allow me to call on Member States to use this Session to forge a new consensus of uniting behind a shared determination to make the United Nations a potent instrument to realise our common purposes and aspirations as one human family. This is our only planet. Let us preserve it for posterity.

The Gambia is committedly disposed to participating actively in making the world a better place for all. On behalf of His Excellency Mr. Adama Barrow and the Government and People of The Gambia, I wish you all fruitful deliberations to advance the theme of this 80th Session of the General Assembly.

Thank you very much for your attention.